

PARTICIPANT INFORMATION LETTER and Consent Form (PICF)

Online Survey

PROJECT TITLE:

APPLICATION NUMBER: (2026- 4960)

PRINCIPAL INVESTIGATOR: Jiesi Guo

Dear Participant,

You are invited to participate in the research project described below.

1. What is the project about?

This research project aims to better understand parents' capacity to support their children's online safety and privacy in everyday digital contexts. As children's use of digital technologies continues to grow, parents play a vital role in guiding their online behaviours, helping them navigate potential risks, and fostering safer digital practices at home. As part of this study, participants will be invited to take part in an online program that provides information and practical guidance on supporting children's online safety and privacy. The study will also examine parents' awareness of online risks, their confidence in managing these risks, and the quality of the parent-child relationship. You are invited to take part because you are a parent or caregiver of a school-aged child.

2. Who is undertaking the project?

This project is being conducted by Prof. Jiesi Guo from the Institute for Positive Psychology and Education (IPPE) at the Australian Catholic University. Prof. Guo has a strong background in developmental and educational psychology, along with several years of experience in parenting research and the design and implementation of programs incorporating digital tools and AI-supported approaches. The research team also includes Dr. Chloe Gordon, who specialises in media literacy and school-based research, and Dr. Kim Rowston, who has expertise in learning technologies and educational design. The project is also supported by Ying Ma (PhD candidate; research assistant), who has experience working on school-based research. Together, the team brings both theoretical and practical expertise relevant to this project.

This research is funded by [ACU Faculty of Education and Arts Discovery Grant - 906396](#))

3. Who can take part in this study?

Participation in this study is subject to certain eligibility criteria:

You can take part if you:

- are aged 18 years or older;
- are currently living in Australia;

- are a parent or primary caregiver of a child in Years 7–9.

You will not be able to take part if you do not meet the above criteria.

4. What will I need to do to participate in this study??

If you decide to take part in this research, you will be asked to complete a series of online surveys. These surveys will include questions about your awareness of online safety and privacy risks, your confidence in managing these risks, and how you communicate with your child about online experiences and your relationship with your child.

All participants will complete:

- a pre-study survey before the program begins;
- a second survey approximately four weeks later.

Some participants will also be asked to complete:

- a third survey after completing the program.

Each survey will take approximately 10–15 minutes to complete.

Participants will be placed into one of two groups. One group will begin a short online program shortly after the first survey. The other group will receive access to the same program after a delay of approximately four weeks.

The program consists of eight brief video episodes (approximately 8 minutes each), designed to support parents in managing children's online safety and privacy risks in everyday situations.

Your survey responses will be linked using a non-identifying code generated by the survey system. Your login details (e.g., email address) will be stored separately from your survey responses, so that your responses remain confidential.

5. Do I have to take part in this research?

There is no obligation to participate in this research and if you do not wish to take part, you do not have to. Your participation is completely voluntary, and you may withdraw without consequence and without providing a reason at any stage. Your decision to participate or not, or to take part and withdraw, will in no way affect your relationship with the Australian Catholic University or any parties involved in this research.

Before deciding to take part in this research study, please read the information carefully and feel free to ask questions, or to talk things over with a relative or friend.

If you agree to participate in this study, you will be asked to provide your consent by completing an online Consent Form at the end of this document and to keep a copy of this form.

6. Are there any risks associated with participating in this project?

Whilst there are no foreseeable risks associated with participating in this study, you may find some of the questions about your child's online experiences or online safety and privacy risks to be uncomfortable or upsetting.

If you become distressed or upset by any of the questions, you may take a break, or simply stop and close your browser, as participation in this research is completely voluntary.

If you require support from someone not involved in this research, you may contact the following free services:

Beyond Blue	Call a counsellor on 1300 22 4636 or webchat: https://www.beyondblue.org.au/who-does-it-affect/young-people/helpful-contacts-and-websites
Kids Helpline	Call a counsellor on 1800 55 1800
Reach out	Webchat: https://au.reachout.com/
Headspace	Call a counsellor on 1800 650 890 or webchat: headspace.org.au
School counselling service Please contact your school's counselling service (check your school office or website for details, or ask your teacher for guidance if you're unsure).	

7. Are there any costs or reimbursements involved?

There are no costs associated with participating in this study. Participants will have the option to enter a prize draw to win AUD \$25 gift cards as a token of appreciation for their time.

At the end of the survey, a separate link will be provided where you can choose to enter your contact details if you wish to participate in the draw. Your contact information will be collected separately and will not be linked to your survey responses.

8. What are the benefits of the research project?

Although there may be no direct benefits to you from this research, the findings may contribute to a better understanding of parents' awareness, confidence, and practices in supporting children's online safety. This research may help inform the development of future educational resources and programs designed to support parents in managing children's online experiences and promoting safer online behaviours.

9. Can I withdraw from the study?

Participation in this study is completely voluntary. You are not under any obligation to participate. If you agree to participate, you can withdraw from the study at any time without adverse consequences by closing your browser before submitting the survey, and your data will not be used for this study.

Once you have submitted the survey, we will not be able to withdraw your responses, as the data are de-identified and your responses cannot be identified.

10. Will anyone else know the results of the project or have access to my information?

Any information or personal details gathered during this study are confidential and will not be shared with third parties without your consent, unless required by law. The data from this research project will be securely stored on ACU systems, including REDCap and password-protected institutional storage (OneDrive), and will be retained for 15 years in accordance with ACU data retention policies.

ACU will manage your personal information and share data in accordance with its Privacy Policy. In limited circumstances, authorised ACU systems or IT personnel may access data to maintain or troubleshoot secure systems.

11. Will I be able to find out the results of the project?

The results of this study may be published in academic journals. All findings will be presented in an aggregated format, meaning that no individual participants will be identifiable. If you would like to receive a summary of the results, you may contact a member of the research team listed below.

12. Who do I contact if I have questions about the project?

If you have any questions or concerns about the project, please contact a member/s of the research team below.

Name	Prof. Jiesi Guo
Position	Professor
Telephone	+61 (0)297014700
Email	Jiesi.Guo@acu.edu.au

What if I have a complaint or any concerns about the research study?

The study has been reviewed by the Human Research Ethics Committee at Australian Catholic University (review number 2026-4960). If you have any complaints or concerns about the conduct of the project, you may email the Manager of Research Ethics and Integrity, the Office of the Deputy Vice Chancellor (Research and Enterprise) at Resethics.manager@acu.edu.au

Any complaint or concern will be treated in confidence and reviewed and acted upon, as appropriate.

I understand that data analysis will be conducted using various research software tools (e.g., statistical software, qualitative analysis programs, AI-assisted tools) within the university's secure systems).

13. I want to participate, what do I have to do?

Participation in this study is voluntary. If you would like to take part, you can indicate your by clicking 'yes, I agree to participate' after the Consent statement below and clicking the submit button at the end of the survey, you are providing your permission for the research team to collect and use collect and use your responses for the purposes of this study.

Yours sincerely,

Prof. Jiesi Guo



Please retain a copy of this information letter insert weblink or PDF